

AND THE WINNER IS... EPS and other leaders at the GC meet in Chennai, Jul 11; (L) OPS

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A NEW AIADMK

At its July 11 meet, the AIADMK general council (GC) reverted to the earlier hierarchy of an all-powerful general secretary (GS) at the helm rather than a system of dual leadership. In keeping with the Tamil penchant for honorifics, the party's presidium chairman Tamil Magan Hussain proposed that the new interim GS be called 'Ezhuchi Nayagan'. Others want to call him Puratchi Thalaimagan.

Fresh elections to the post of GS will be held in four months. The GS will have a five-year tenure and will choose a deputy GS, also for a five-year term. The GC also amended party laws to allow only those who have 10 years' standing in the AIADMK or have been office-bearers at the party HQ for five years to contest for the GS. Ten district secretaries have to propose the nomination to the post of GS and another 10 have to second it.

With these changes in its constitution, the AIADMK has stepped out of Jayalalithaa's shadow and their veneration of her as an 'eternal GS.' However, both the amendments and the 'Two Leaves' poll symbol are likely to be contested in court and before the ECI.

extensively in the hope of regaining her clout in the AIADMK. "Only the person who is chosen by the cadre will be GS," she claims. "It is the wish of the cadre and the people that I should be the GS." She contends that the general council meet is invalid because the case she filed on stripping her of the GS post is pending in the high court.

Moving swiftly, EPS amended the party constitution—stipulating that only someone who has been a party member for 10 years or an office-bearer for five years at the party HQ is eligible to contest for the GS post—and hastily submitted it to the Election Commission. But to cover all bases, he needed to think beyond the law too. Minus the personality-based cults of a Jayalalithaa or an MGR, politics devolves back into caste equations. So EPS took care to mollify Sasikala and OPS's Mukkulathor-Thevar caste cohort, which is dominant in south Tamil Nadu. A Gounder from the western district of Salem, EPS is projecting himself as a caste-neutral leader but is treading the minefield with caution. He got R.B. Udayakumar and O.S. Manian, Thevars both, to read out the resolutions at the general council meeting. And C. Sreenivasan has replaced fellow Thevar OPS as treasurer.

Not many give Chinnamma, as Sasikala is known, a chance now since she drew her strength from Jayalalithaa—minus that sun, the satellite is devoid of light. Observers do not see her emerging as a major influence, leave alone being in any danger of taking over the reins of the AIADMK. The only way the challengers can pose a threat to EPS is if they bury the hatchet and join hands. Sasikala's nephew T.T.V. Dhinakaran, who floated the breakaway Amma Makkal Munnetra Kazhagam (AMMK), has said he will work to reunite all factions. Such a phalanx could dent the AIADMK's base in south Tamil Nadu. Problem is, none of them have Jayalalithaa's charisma that can command unalloyed loyalty from the cadre. Even EPS, who may have won custody of the party for now, does not have it in him to play a long-term helmsman. Which can only be good news for the DMK. And perhaps for the BJP, which is hoping to capitalise on the convulsions within its ally. It may well limit its handholding of the Dravidian major now and keep in sight the aim of winning a few seats in 2024. ■